



ENCIRCLED BY UNREST
From left, the foreign ministers of India and China, S. Jaishankar and Wang Yi, at the ASEAN foreign ministers' meeting, Vientiane, Jul. 27; Maldivian parties at an 'India Out' rally in Male, 2022

saw our relationship with the country deteriorate in this vital outpost of the Indian Ocean. From 2018 to 2023, when President Ibrahim Solih ruled, India had made substantial strides in economic and security arrangements. We were able to successfully reverse most of the anti-India policies that the previous pro-China regimes had pushed through, though not the cancellation of a $500 million airport project with the GMR group in 2010. But with Solih losing the presidential election to Mohamed Muizzu, who ran an "India Out" campaign, relations nosedived once again. Ordering all Indian military personnel to leave, Muizzu cancelled several earlier defence agreements. He then went on to sign 20 agreements with China to reduce the Maldives' dependence on India for food imports, health facilities and trade. Worse, China now plans to develop a naval base in the Maldives that could pose a threat not only to our strategic initiatives in the Indian Ocean but our security directly.



"OUR RECORD IN NEIGHBOURING COUNTRIES IS PATCHY, OUR AID COMMITMENT TO THEM HAS DIMINISHED OVER TIME"

–SHIVSHANKAR MENON *Former NSA*

Likewise, the frequent changes of prime ministers have seen Indian fortunes fluctuate in the Himalayan nation of Nepal. Prime Minister K.P. Sharma Oli is seen as pro-China and had in his previous tenure between 2018 and 2020 stirred up nationalistic fervour by printing a contentious new map delineating India's three disputed border areas with Nepal as its own, ignoring ongoing negotiations. He then formalised it by ramming through a constitutional amendment. Oli, who heads the Communist Party of Nepal – Unified Marxist-Leninist (CPN-UML), had also actively cultivated better relations with China and entered into several agreements to build infrastructure projects that had India gnashing its teeth. Now, he is back in the saddle, after entering into the unlikeliest of alliances with the Nepali Congress a month ago. An alliance that Ranjit Rae, a former ambassador to Nepal, sees as akin to the BJP and Congress forming a coalition government. Though the Sher Bahadur Deuba-led Nepali Congress is seen as pro-India, Rae warns against complacency. "The Chinese and Americans are very active in Nepal and India should be far more engaged with all players in the country," he says. "We shouldn't put all our eggs in one basket as we did in Bangladesh."

THE CHINA FACTOR

In Myanmar, which shares a long border with India, many experts say the Modi government is again in danger of making the same mistake it did in Bangladesh. India continues to back the Gen. Hlaing-led State Administration Council (SAC). The junta is seen as widely unpopular, yet India is allegedly selling it arms and ammunition, which the army in turn uses to quell internal rebellions. Here again, it's the youth that are leading the unrest against the country's poor economic situation—Myanmar has a negative GDP growth. Gautam Mukhopadhaya, a former Indian ambassador to Myanmar, says, "India is perceived as being with the SAC, which means that the vast majority of Myanmar's population views us negatively. Myanmar is being driven now by federal and democratic sentiments and India has the opportunity of